A · UNDERSTANDING THE MIND & BODY

How the Brain Creates & Regulates Emotions

Draws on constructionist emotion science and Gross's process model of emotion regulation

1 WHAT IS IT?

An emotion is a whole-person response to what's happening, built from what you notice around you, what you feel in your body, and what past experience tells you it means. Emotions aren't flaws to fix. They carry information and energy for action.

2 HOW DOES IT WORK?



Adapted from James Gross's process model of emotion regulation. A simplified map for reflection, not a literal picture of the brain.

3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

Your brain is always predicting. It blends signals from the world with signals from inside your body (heartbeat, breath, muscle tension) and with past experience to make sense of the moment. The felt result is what we call an emotion.

There is no single "emotion center." Areas like the amygdala help flag what matters, and areas of the prefrontal cortex help put things in context, but emotions arise from many networks working together. Under stress, fast protective reactions can lead before slower reflection catches up. That's survival design, not a personal failing.

Normal or a concern? Everyone has intense feelings sometimes. If emotions feel overwhelming most days, last for weeks, or make daily life hard, that's a good reason to reach out for support.

4 WHAT CAN HELP?

Put it into words

Naming a feeling, even silently ("this is disappointment"), is linked to calmer emotional responses in affect-labeling research. The more specific, the better.

Look again at the meaning

Ask, "Is there another way to see this?" Reappraisal doesn't deny what's hard. It widens the lens, and it's one of the most studied ways people regulate emotion.

Work with your body

Lengthen your exhale, soften your jaw and shoulders, or feel your feet on the floor. Changing body signals changes the information your brain is working with.

5 REFLECTION QUESTION

When a strong feeling shows up, where do you notice it first: in your body, your thoughts, or your actions?

6 KEY TAKEAWAY

Emotions are made, not just triggered, so you have more than one place to respond.

7 REFERENCES

1. Barrett, L. F. (2017). *How emotions are made: The secret life of the brain.* Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.
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3. Lieberman, M. D., Eisenberger, N. I., Crockett, M. J., Tom, S. M., Pfeifer, J. H., & Way, B. M. (2007). Putting feelings into words: Affect labeling disrupts amygdala activity in response to affective stimuli. *Psychological Science, 18*(5), 421–428.
4. Pessoa, L. (2017). A network model of the emotional brain. *Trends in Cognitive Sciences, 21*(5), 357–371.

These resources are for education and self-reflection and are not a substitute for individualized mental health care.